



TIOBE Index March 2026: How 20+ Search Engines Rank the World's Programming Languages

A data-forward analysis of programming language popularity trends based on search-engine hit counts across Google, Bing, Wikipedia, Amazon, and 20+ other sites.

March 2026 Monthly Report | TIOBE Programming Community Index

Source: tiobe.com/tiobe-index/

Python Holds #1 at 21.25% but C Surges to #2 with the Largest Gain

Rank (Mar 2026)	Rank (Mar 2025)	Language	Rating	YoY Change
1	1	Python	21.25%	-2.59%
2	4	C	11.55%	+2.02%
3	2	C++	8.18%	-2.90%
4	3	Java	7.99%	-2.37%
5	5	C#	6.36%	+1.49%
6	6	JavaScript	3.45%	-0.01%
7	9	Visual Basic	2.50%	-0.02%
8	8	SQL	2.00%	-0.57%
9	16	R	1.88%	+0.94%
10	10	Delphi/Object Pascal	1.80%	-0.36%
11	24	Perl	1.75%	+1.05%
12	12	Scratch	1.63%	-0.03%
13	11	Fortran	1.45%	-0.25%
14	14	Rust	1.31%	+0.09%
15	15	MATLAB	1.29%	+0.31%
16	7	Go	1.29%	-1.49%
17	17	Assembly language	1.29%	+0.42%
18	13	PHP	1.23%	-0.25%

Source: TIOBE Programming Community Index, March 2026

Perl Jumps 13 Spots, R Climbs 7, and Go Drops 9 -- The Biggest Rank Shifts of 2026

GAINERS

Perl	24th → 11th	+13
R	16th → 9th	+7
Swift	26th → 20th	+6
C	4th → 2nd	+2
C#	5th → 5th	—

LOSERS

Go	7th → 16th	-9
C++	2nd → 3rd	-1
Java	3rd → 4th	-1
PHP	13th → 18th	-5
Python	1st → 1st	—

From Lisp at #2 in 1986 to Python at #1 in 2026: How Language Rankings Shifted Over Time

Language	2026	2021	2016	2011	2006	2001	1996	1991	1986
Python	1	3	5	7	8	26	17	—	—
C	2	1	2	2	2	1	1	1	1
C++	3	4	3	3	3	2	2	2	9
Java	4	2	1	1	1	3	31	—	—
C#	5	5	4	5	7	11	—	—	—
JavaScript	6	7	8	10	10	8	33	—	—
Go	10	11	60	16	—	—	—	—	—
Ada	14	36	25	22	16	18	6	10	3
Lisp	26	34	26	13	14	19	8	4	2

Key Historical Patterns

- Python's meteoric rise: from unranked before 1991 to #1 by 2026, peaking above 25%
- C has remained in the top 2 across all nine measurement points spanning four decades
- Java dominated from 2005–2018 but fell from 25%+ to under 8%; Lisp fell from #2 (1986) to #26

Python Wins Language of the Year 6 Times -- More Than Any Other Language

Year	Winner
2025	C#
2024	Python
2023	C#
2022	C++
2021	Python
2020	Python
2019	C
2018	Python
2016	Go

Insights

- Python has won the award six times (2007, 2010, 2018, 2020, 2021, 2024) — more than any other language.
- C# took the title in both 2023 and 2025, reflecting continued growth driven by the .NET ecosystem.
- Go won in 2016, but has since fallen from 7th to 16th — a notable reversal.
- The 2017 winner is not available in the source data.

The Top 4 Languages Hold 49% of the Index: What This Means for Your Tech Stack

Python: Dominant but Declining

At 21.25%, Python leads by a wide margin, yet its -2.59 pp YoY drop is the largest among the top 5. Monitor trajectory before over-investing.

C's Resurgence

C gained +2.02 pp and climbed from 4th to 2nd. Its 24-year top-2 consistency makes it a low-risk systems-language bet.

Legacy Language Revival

Perl (+13 ranks), R (+7), and Fortran (top 15) show entrenched communities in data science and infrastructure still matter.

Go's Sharp Decline

Go fell from 7th to 16th (-1.49 pp). Consider Rust (14th, +0.09%) for new systems projects given Go's displacement risk.

Concentration Risk

Python, C, C++, and Java hold 48.97% of the index. Diversify hiring and training to avoid over-dependence on a shrinking pool.

Mobile & Cross-Platform

Swift re-entered the top 20 (+6 ranks) while Kotlin dropped to 22nd. Apple-platform growth favors Swift investment.